CLIFFHANGER

vey rolls on—under a court greenlight, and a boycott shadow



DISPUTED SURVEY Officials during the caste census in Hubballi, Karnataka, Sept. 23; below, CM Siddaramaiah and Deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar

PTI





thing more enlightening than a long bureaucratic coma?

The logistics of the door-to-door survey presently under way are already daunting: it aims to cover about 14.37 million households and 70 million citizens within a 16-day window, ending October 7. The report is slated to be out by December—if all goes well. More formidable than its demographic footprint is the demonology it has to surmount. Not that it was unexpected. In August, when the Siddaramaiah-led government ordered the survey, it was precisely because of the opposition its 2015 forerunner faced. Dubbed a 'caste census', that one had scythed through a forbidding path—only to fall to a veto from Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas, who feared a drop in their population estimates and consequently decried it as 'unscientific'.

The 2015 data thus stayed under wraps till 2023 when Siddaramaiah, back as CM, ordered that it be utilised by the Karnataka State Backward Classes Commission (KSBCC), which had conducted the exercise, to prepare a report afresh. While its recommendations were to increase OBC reservations from 32 per cent to 51 per cent and revise the backward lists, the accompanying caste-wise break-up placed Veerashaiva-Lingayats at only 11.1 per cent of the state's population and Vokkaligas at 10.3 per cent. Both communities dismissed it as an undercount. After much deliberation, the Congress in July this year decided to shelve this report, opting instead for a fresh survey since the data was anyway a decade old.

RASH OF DISPUTANTS

But pressure mounted closer to its launch, with unease spreading among some of Siddaramaiah's own cabinet members. On September 18, the judicial challenge began. The Rajya Vokkaligara Sangha, the All India Veerashaiva Mahasabha and the Akhila Karnataka Brahmana Mahasabha approached the Karnataka High Court, asking that the government be restrained from conducting the survey. Arguing that its socio-economic terms of reference were a 'subterfuge' and the idea was only to elicit a headcount, the petitioners contended that the power to conduct a census vests exclusively with the Union government. Among other objections, the survey was also accused of violating the right to privacy and of collecting demographic statistics for electoral gains.

The government had a defence ready. A survey was necessary, it argued, because apex court orders in the 1992 Indra Sawhney case had laid down mandatory guidelines for identification of backward classes, which entailed a periodic review of the population. Besides, neither of the previous surveys—Bihar (2023) and Telangana (2024)—were interdicted. The high court, accordingly, declined to grant a stay in its interim order on September 25. However, it added a vital caveat: the KSBCC was to not only ensure data confidentiality, it would have to issue a public notice clarifying that participation in the survey was purely voluntary.

For the BJP's Bengaluru South MP, Tejasvi Surya, that was reason enough